JOURNEY THROUGH JONAH · SESSION 1

On the Run

Jonah 1:1–16

TO GET STARTED

As a child, what did you do to get out of a chore you didn't want to do – and did it work?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Jonah was a well-known prophet in Israel who had announced good news for his own nation (2 Kings 14:25). Now God sends him to Nineveh, a capital of the brutal Assyrian Empire – Israel's most feared enemy. Tonight we follow Jonah from the call, onto a ship heading the opposite way, and into a storm.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 1:1–4

[1] The word of the LORD came to Jonah son of Amittai: [2] "Get up, go to Nineveh, the
great city, and cry out against it, for their evil has come up before my face." [3] So
Jonah got up – to flee to Tarshish, away from the face of the LORD. He went down to
Joppa and found a ship bound for Tarshish. He paid the fare and went down into it,
to go with them to Tarshish, away from the face of the LORD.

[4] But the LORD hurled a great wind onto the sea, and there was a great storm on the
sea, so that the ship threatened to break apart.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 1:5–7

5 The sailors were afraid, and each cried out to his own god. They hurled the cargo
that was in the ship into the sea to lighten it for themselves. But Jonah had gone
down into the innermost part of the ship, had lain down, and had fallen into a deep
sleep. 6 The captain came to him and said to him, "What are you doing asleep? Get
up, call out to your god! Perhaps that god will give a thought to us, and we will not
perish." 7 Then they said to one another, "Come, let us cast lots, so that we may know
on whose account this evil has come upon us." So they cast lots, and the lot fell on
Jonah.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 1:8–10

8 Then they said to him, "Tell us, please, on whose account this evil has come upon
us! What is your work, and where do you come from? What is your country, and
from what people are you?" 9 He said to them, "A Hebrew am I, and the LORD, the God
of heaven, I fear – he who made the sea and the dry land." 10 Then the men feared
with a great fear and said to him, "What is this you have done!" For the men knew
that he was fleeing from the face of the LORD, because he had told them.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 1:11–13

11 And they said to him, "What shall we do to you, so that the sea will calm down for
us?" For the sea was growing more and more stormy. 12 He said to them, "Pick me up
and hurl me into the sea, and the sea will calm down for you. For I know that it is on
my account that this great storm has come upon you." 13 The men rowed hard to get
back to dry land, but they could not, for the sea was growing more and more stormy
against them.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 1:14–16

14 Then they called out to the LORD and said, "Please, LORD, do not let us perish for this
man's life, and do not lay innocent blood on us! For you, LORD, have done as you
pleased." 15 Then they picked Jonah up and hurled him into the sea, and the sea
stopped its raging. 16 Then the men feared the LORD with a great fear; they offered a
sacrifice to the LORD and made vows.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

קוּם

qum · “get up”

God says “Get up, go” (1:2). Jonah does get up – but to flee (1:3). And the pagan captain later shakes him with the very same word: “Get up, call out to your god!” (1:6).

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

יָרַד

yarad · “go down”

Jonah goes down to Joppa, down into the ship, down into its innermost part (1:3, 5). Every step away from God's call is a step downward, while Nineveh's evil “has come up” before God (1:2).

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

טוּל

tul · “hurl”

The LORD hurls a great wind (1:4), the sailors hurl the cargo (1:5) and finally hurl Jonah (1:15). The same verb shows who is really in control of the storm.

THE BIG IDEA

God's call does not let go of us when we run – he sends a storm of grace that brings us, and those around us, back to him.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

What exactly does God ask Jonah to do, and what does Jonah do instead? Look closely at the words in verses 2 and 3.

Jonah 1:2–3

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Everything seems to go smoothly for Jonah: a ship is ready and he can pay the fare. Why is an “open door” not always proof of God's will?

Jonah 1:3

DISCUSSION · 3/7

While the sailors pray and work, Jonah sleeps. What does this picture tell us about spiritual numbness?

Jonah 1:5–6

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Jonah says, “A Hebrew am I, and the LORD, the God of heaven, I fear.” In what way is his confession right, and in what way does his life contradict it?

Jonah 1:9

DISCUSSION · 5/7

The men “rowed hard” to reach land (literally, they “dug”). Where do we try to solve with our own strength something only obedience can solve?

Jonah 1:13

DISCUSSION · 6/7

The storm starts with men who fear the sea and ends with men who “feared the LORD with a great fear”. What has God done through Jonah's disobedience?

Jonah 1:16

DISCUSSION · 7/7

What is your “Nineveh” – and your “Tarshish” – at the moment? Share only what you are comfortable sharing.

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one specific “Nineveh” (a conversation, an act of forgiveness, a task) and take one small step towards it this week.
- Notice one “Tarshish” you use to escape God's voice (busyness, screens, overwork) and set aside ten quiet minutes each day instead.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray in pairs or threes: thank God that he pursues us even when we run, and ask him for the courage to “get up” in the one area each person named. Close by praying together for people who are suffering because of our own “storms”.

JOURNEY THROUGH JONAH · SESSION 2

From the Depths

Jonah 2:1–11

TO GET STARTED

Think of a time when you were completely stuck – a flat tyre, a lost key, a cancelled flight. What went through your mind?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Jonah has been thrown into the sea, and the storm has stopped. But the story is not over: the LORD appoints a great fish. From inside it, in total darkness, Jonah prays. Note: this chapter follows the Hebrew verse numbers – English Bibles number 2:1 as 1:17 and 2:2–11 as 2:1–10.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 2:1–3

[1] But the LORD appointed a great fish to swallow Jonah. And Jonah was in the belly of
the fish three days and three nights. (*English Bibles*: 1:17) [2] Then Jonah prayed to the
LORD his God from the belly of the fish [3] and said:

I called out of my distress to the LORD,
and he answered me;
from the belly of the grave I cried for help –
you heard my voice.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 2:4–5

4 You had thrown me into the deep,
into the heart of the seas,
and the current surrounded me;
all your breakers and your waves
passed over me.
5 And I – I said, "I am driven away
from before your eyes.
Yet I will look again
towards your holy temple."

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 2:6–7

6 Waters closed around me up to my throat,
the deep surrounded me,
seaweed was wrapped around my head.
7 To the roots of the mountains I went down;
the earth – its bars closed behind me for ever.
But you brought my life up from the pit,
LORD my God.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 2:8–10

8 When my soul was fainting within me,
I remembered the LORD,
and my prayer came to you,
into your holy temple.
9 Those who cling to worthless idols
abandon their faithful love.
10 But I, with a voice of thanksgiving,
will sacrifice to you;
what I have vowed I will pay.
Salvation belongs to the LORD!

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 2:11–11

11 Then the LORD spoke to the fish, and it vomited Jonah out onto the dry land.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

מָנָה

manah · “appoint”

God appoints the great fish (2:1) – and later the plant, the worm and the wind (4:6–8). The fish is not an accident or a punishment but God's chosen means of rescue.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

חֶסֶד

chesed · “faithful love”

God's loyal covenant love that never gives up. “Those who cling to worthless idols abandon their faithful love” (2:9): whatever we cling to instead of God robs us of it.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

יְשׁוּעָה

yeshu'ah · "salvation"

"Salvation belongs to the LORD!" (2:10). The name Yeshua – Jesus – comes from the same root.

THE BIG IDEA

At the lowest point of his flight, Jonah discovers that God was in charge all along – and that salvation belongs to the LORD alone.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

How do you read the great fish: as punishment or as rescue? What does the word “appointed” suggest?

Jonah 2:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Jonah says to God, “You had thrown me into the deep” – although the sailors threw him. What does it mean to see God's hand behind our crisis?

Jonah 2:4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“I am driven away from before your eyes. Yet I will look again towards your holy temple.” What is the “yet” of faith, and where have you needed it?

Jonah 2:5

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“To the roots of the mountains I went down … But you brought my life up from the pit.” How does this verse complete the “going down” we saw in chapter 1?

Jonah 2:7

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Jonah says, “I remembered the LORD” when his soul was fainting. What helps you to remember God when you are exhausted?

Jonah 2:8

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Jonah praises God before he is out of the fish. Why is praise in the dark so powerful – and so hard?

Jonah 2:10

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Jesus calls his death and resurrection “the sign of Jonah” (Matthew 12:40). Where do you see the gospel in this chapter?

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Learn one verse of Jonah's psalm by heart this week, so that you carry God's word with you into “dark” days.
- Name one “worthless idol” you cling to for security, and each day say aloud instead: “Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

PRAY TOGETHER

Read 2:3 together aloud. Then let each person who wishes name one situation where they need a “yet” of faith, and pray for each other briefly. Close by saying together: “Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

JOURNEY THROUGH JONAH · SESSION 3

Overturned

Jonah 3:1–10

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever been given a second chance – a second attempt at an exam, a job or a friendship? What did it feel like?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Jonah has just been vomited out onto the dry land. Chapter 3 opens almost word for word like chapter 1: the word of the LORD comes to Jonah a second time, with the same assignment. This time Jonah gets up and goes – and a sermon of just five Hebrew words sets off the greatest turning of a city in the Bible.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 3:1–5

[1] The word of the LORD came to Jonah a second time: [2] "Get up, go to Nineveh, the
great city, and cry out to it the message that I am telling you." [3] So Jonah got up and
went to Nineveh, as the LORD had said. Now Nineveh was a great city – great even
before God – a three days' journey across. [4] Jonah began to go into the city, one day's
journey, and he cried out and said, "Forty more days, and Nineveh will be
overturned!" [5] And the people of Nineveh believed God. They called a fast and put on
sackcloth, from the greatest of them to the least.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 3:6–8

6 When the word reached the king of Nineveh, he got up from his throne, took off
his royal robe, covered himself with sackcloth, and sat in the ashes. 7 And he had it
cried out in Nineveh and said: "By decree of the king and his great men: let neither
man nor beast, herd nor flock taste anything; let them not graze, and let them not
drink water. 8 Let man and beast be covered with sackcloth, and let them call out to
God with all their strength. Let each one turn from his evil way and from the
violence that is in his hands.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 3:9–10

9 Who knows? God may turn and relent; he may turn from his burning anger, so
that we do not perish." 10 And God saw what they did, that they turned from their
evil way. And God relented of the evil that he had said he would do to them, and he
did not do it.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

שֵׁנִית

shenit · “a second time”

One small word holds an ocean of grace. God could have chosen another prophet, but his word comes to Jonah again: his calling rests on his faithfulness, not on our failure.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

נֶהְפָּכָת

nehpakhet · “overturned”

From hafakh, the word used for the destruction of Sodom (Genesis 19:25) – but it can also mean "turned around", "completely changed". Nineveh was indeed overturned within forty days: not by fire, but by repentance.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

שׁוּב

shuv · “turn”

The hinge of chapter 3. The people are to turn from their evil way (v. 8); the king hopes God may turn from his burning anger (v. 9); and when they turn, God relents of the evil he had said he would do (v. 10).

THE BIG IDEA

God speaks to his runaway prophet a second time, and a violent city believes God and turns – God's grace overturns hearts, not only cities.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Put 1:1–3 and 3:1–3 side by side. What is the same, and what has changed? Notice the shift from "cry out against it" (1:2) to "cry out to it the message that I am telling you" (3:2).

Jonah 3:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Jonah's whole sermon is: "Forty more days, and Nineveh will be overturned!" What is missing from it? Why do you think it worked anyway?

Jonah 3:4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

"Overturned" can mean destroyed or turned around. In what sense was Nineveh "overturned" after all?

Jonah 3:10

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The turning starts among ordinary people and then reaches the throne. Look at the four things the king does in verse 6. What does each one say?

Jonah 3:6

DISCUSSION · 5/7

The king says, "Who knows? God may turn and relent." Compare the captain in 1:6: "Perhaps that god will give a thought to us." What do these two pagans understand about approaching God that Jonah seems to have forgotten?

Jonah 3:9

DISCUSSION · 6/7

"And God saw what they did, that they turned from their evil way." What does real turning look like in verses 8 and 10? What might "the violence that is in his hands" be for us today?

Jonah 3:8

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Nineveh was "a great city – great even before God". Whom have we written off as beyond God's reach? What would change if we saw them as great before God?

Jonah 3:3

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one "point of disobedience" you need to go back to – something God asked of you that you left undone – and take the first "one day's journey" step this week.
- Choose one person or group you have written off. Pray for them by name every day this week.

PRAY TOGETHER

Thank God together that his word comes "a second time". Then hold a minute of silence in which each person brings before God what is in their hands that they need to let go of. Close by praying aloud, briefly and by name, for people and places that seem beyond reach.

JOURNEY THROUGH JONAH · SESSION 4

The Unanswered Question

Jonah 4:1–11

TO GET STARTED

What small thing can ruin your mood in an instant – a hot day, a slow internet connection, a missed bus? What does that say about us?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Nineveh has been spared. Instead of rejoicing, Jonah is furious – and now we finally learn why he ran to Tarshish. He sits east of the city to see what will happen, and God teaches him with a plant, a worm and a scorching east wind. The book ends with God's question, and no answer from Jonah.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 4:1–4

[1] But to Jonah this was evil – a great evil – and his anger burned. [2] He prayed to the LORD and said, "Please, LORD, is this not what I said while I was still in my own country? That is why I fled to Tarshish in the first place. For I knew that you are a gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abounding in faithful love, and one who relents over evil. [3] So now, LORD, please take my life from me, for my death is better than my life." [4] But the LORD said, "Is it right for your anger to burn?"

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 4:5–7

5 Jonah went out of the city and sat down east of the city. There he made himself a
shelter and sat under it in the shade, until he could see what would happen in the
city. 6 Then the LORD God appointed a leafy plant and made it grow up over Jonah, to
be shade over his head, to deliver him from his evil. And Jonah rejoiced over the
plant with great joy. 7 But God appointed a worm when dawn came up the next day,
and it struck the plant, so that it withered.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 4:8–10

8 When the sun rose, God appointed a scorching east wind, and the sun struck
Jonah's head, so that he grew faint. He asked that he might die, and said, "My death
is better than my life." 9 But God said to Jonah, "Is it right for your anger to burn
over the plant?" He said, "It is right for my anger to burn – to the point of death!"
10 Then the LORD said, "You had pity on the plant, for which you did not labour and
which you did not make grow; it came into being in a night and perished in a night.

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 4:11–11

11 And should I not have pity on Nineveh, the great city, in which there are more than a hundred and twenty thousand people who do not know their right hand from their left – and many animals as well?"

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

רָעָה גְּדוֹלָה

ra'ah gedolah · "a great evil"

Nineveh's evil came up before God (1:2); they turned from their evil way (3:8); God relented of the evil (3:10). Now: "But to Jonah this was evil – a great evil." God's grace itself is evil in Jonah's eyes.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

חָרָה

charah · "anger burned"

The moment God's burning anger stops (3:9), Jonah's starts. God answers with a quiet question, as he did with Cain (Genesis 4:6): "Is it right for your anger to burn?"

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

חוּס

chus · “have pity”

Jonah has compassion – but for a plant that was "a son of a night". God argues from the lesser to the greater: if you pity the plant, should I not have pity on Nineveh?

THE BIG IDEA

Jonah is angry that God is gracious. Through a plant, a worm and a scorching wind God exposes his small heart – and asks a question the book leaves open for us to answer: should I not have pity?

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Read 4:1–2. Why did Jonah really run to Tarshish? How does this change the way you read chapter 1?

Jonah 4:2

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Jonah quotes Israel's great confession – "a gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abounding in faithful love" (Exodus 34:6) – as an accusation. How can we know true things about God and still resent them?

Jonah 4:2

DISCUSSION · 3/7

God answers Jonah's outburst with a question: "Is it right for your anger to burn?" Why a question and not a rebuke? What is God doing?

Jonah 4:4

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The plant is the only thing in the whole book that makes Jonah happy (4:6); the heat makes him want to die (4:8). What do our joys and our anger reveal about what we value most?

Jonah 4:6

DISCUSSION · 5/7

God "appointed" the fish, the plant, the worm and the wind. What does it mean that even the worm was appointed? Have you known a "worm" like that?

Jonah 4:7

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Read 4:10–11. Compare what Jonah pities with what God pities. What argument is God making – and why does he mention the animals at the very end?

Jonah 4:11

DISCUSSION · 7/7

The book ends with a question. How would you answer it – for yourself, and for the "Nineveh" in your own life that you find hard to love?

Jonah 4:11

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Think of one person you hold an "older brother" resentment against (Luke 15:25–32). Pray a blessing on them every day this week.
- Write down your own one-sentence answer to God's question in 4:11, and share it with one person in the group.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with a minute of silence before God's question in 4:11. Then pray for the people and places we find hard to love, and thank God that he is "slow to anger and abounding in faithful love" – towards them, and towards us.